Maharashtra, Delhi, Karnataka and UP, winning 296 out of the 327 seats in these 13 states. That is a phenomenal strike rate of 90 per cent in these seats. And of the 303 seats the BJP won, it secured a vote percentage of over 50 per cent in 224. This gives the BJP a decisive advantage at the starting block because any party that hopes to defeat it in these seats has to ensure a massive vote swing of around 5 per cent or more. The Opposition will find this tough because despite being in the saddle for 10 years, PM Modi retains his high popularity ratings and defies anti-incumbency, as INDIA TODAY's Mood of the Nation (MOTN) poll demonstrated this February.

But despite knowing it's in a comfortable position, the BJP is leaving nothing to chance. Such is the intensity of the strategising by PM Modi, Union home minister Amit Shah and BJP president J.P. Nadda that, for the past two and a half years, the party has been working relentlessly to guard Fort BJP while expanding its dominion elsewhere. This it did by deploying its cadres in what it called 'Gaon Chalo' and 'Viksit Bharat' campaigns, to spread across over a million booths and inform potential voters about the Modi government's social sector schemes and its grand plan for a Mahan Bharat by 2047 when the nation completes 100 years of Independence. February also saw the culmination of the BJP's 18-month-old 'Lok Sabha Pravas' initiative, in which 45 Union ministers were tasked with strengthening 160-odd weak seats through frequent visits and energising the BJP cadre. Out of these seats, the party had lost 131 in 2019, and won the remainder narrowly, whether on its own or via erstwhile allies.

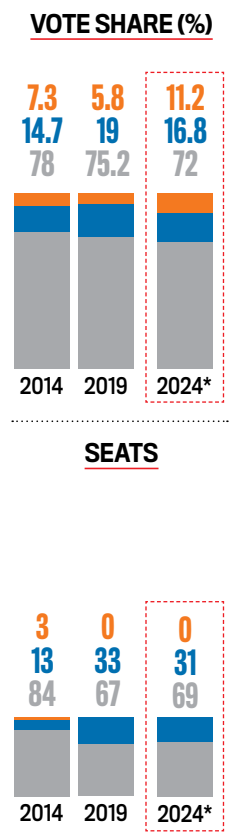
The BJP then pulled out all the stops to win the three Hindi heartland states—Rajasthan, Chhattisgarh and Madhya Pradesh—which went to the polls in the winter of 2023. Post the

THE 100-200-243 SCENARIO

Yashwant Deshmukh, founder-director, CVoter, divides the 543 Lok Sabha seats into three groups to explain the poll arithmetic

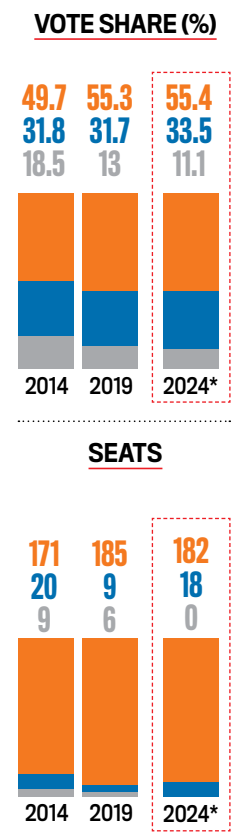
Tough seats for the BJP: 100

The BJP is virtually absent in these 100 seats. In fact, its cumulative vote share dropped to 5.8 per cent and tally to nought in these seats in 2019. Even if it doubles the vote share, the BJP won't be able to win a single seat. Still, it could spring a surprise in seats like Kanyakumari and Coimbatore



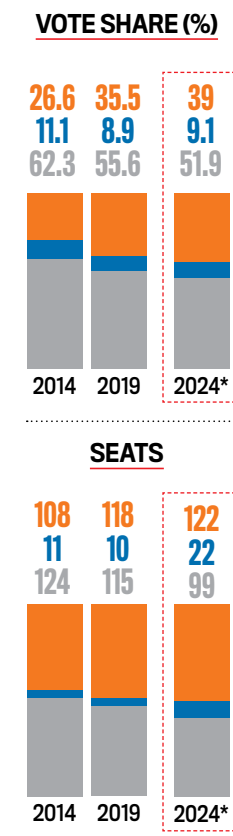
BJP-Congress in a direct fight: 200

These are the seats where the vote share gap between the BJP and the Congress shot up to nearly 25 percentage points in 2019, helping the former corner 185, or 92.5 per cent, seats. No matter what the Congress does, the status quo is unlikely to change. But it also means there's not much for the BJP to add to its tally



BJP vs regional parties: 243

Pitted against regional parties, these are the seats that are most critical and will make the real difference in the BJP's quest for 370 seats and for the NDA to cross 400. The question is whether the BJP's vote share can go up further from the 35.5 per cent it had notched in 2019



*Possible scenario based on the MOTN Feb. 2024 Poll BJP Cong. Others